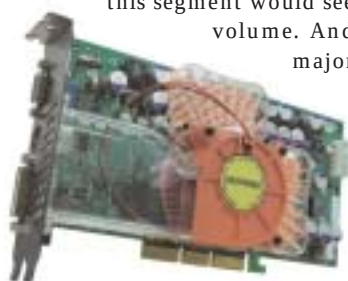


845 chipset for the Pentium 4, more suitable for business class users. TNT2 chipset cards are available for around Rs 1,000 to Rs 1,500. On the other hand, motherboards supporting AMD processors have the NForce 2, which is more suitable for those who aren't avid gamers. These onboard graphics cards from nVidia and ATi have been a great success, and helped vendors bring down the cost of PCs by at least 15 to 20 per cent.

Market reports indicate that in the coming months, this segment would see little momentum in terms of volume. And at the technology level, no major development is predicted.



Apart from the GeForce FX launched recently, the new roadmap from nVidia does not indicate any further development in the high-end graphics cards segment. Only a drop in prices for mid-range and high-end

cards would persuade users to buy newer cards.

The speaker segment has also seen a major upward shift in terms of technology and availability of brands. Almost all PCs sold today support multimedia, and so speakers have become virtually indispensable. Brands like Creative, Logitech, Altec Lansing, Typhoon, Frontech and Samsung are the front-runners; with a market share of around 70 to 80 per cent. Other brands like Artis, Bose, JBL, Mercury and Sumoku are not far behind, and doing quite well in some pockets. Today, the demand for 2.1 and 4.1-channel speakers is on the rise, and prices have dropped by 25 to 30 per cent over the years. Some 4.1 speakers—Artis, for example—are available for as low as Rs 3,000. And some 2.1 speakers—Frontech, Typhoon and Mercury for examples—are available for just Rs 1,200 to Rs 1,500.

Creative recently unveiled its 6.1-channel speakers in the premium segment, at a price tag of Rs 10,000, targeted specifically at movie lovers and hardcore gamers.

Around 80 per cent of the sound cards sold today are onboard, offering basic stereo support and targeting the value segment. Others like Creative Vibra 128 or Audigy offer true 5.1 channel support. Creative also has Extigy, which claims to be the only external sound card available in the world. This was launched last year, keeping in mind the growing demand by professionals for high-fidelity sound cards—to be used by plugging and playing on several PCs. Brands like Zoltrix also figure in smaller numbers, especially in western India, at a competitive price of around Rs 2,000 for a 4.1 speaker set.

Jargon Buster

3D textures: It makes hollow objects solid with true 3D material properties such as wood grain or marbling.

Pixel Shaders: A part of the latest APIs, such as DirectX 9.0, Pixel Shaders allow realistic lighting and surface effects.

Anisotropic filtering: A screen pixel is elongated when it mapped onto the texture space. This is known as anisotropy, a malady that conventional texture filtering techniques (such as bilinear filtering) cannot cure. Anisotropic filtering aims to sharpen a texture by using varying algorithms that basically serve as 'corrective glasses' to alleviate the elongation caused.

it's
unbelievable!



*see page 170-171